title: Exchange on-premises after the October Windows updates: a test plan before you roll out
date: 2026-10-28
summary: Microsoft confirmed that October Windows Server security updates can break OWA sign-in and mail flow on some on-premises Exchange servers. How to test one server first, and why you should not change every server at once.
draft: false

Short answer

If you run on-premises Exchange Server, do not roll the October Windows Server updates to every server at once. Test on one server, check OWA sign-in and mail flow, and read Microsoft's notice before you apply any workaround.

What is known

- BleepingComputer reported on 19 Oct 2026 that Microsoft confirmed the October Windows Server security updates can break OWA sign-in and mail delivery on some on-premises Exchange Server systems.
- Microsoft has shared a temporary registry workaround while it works on a fix, according to the same report.
- The reports describe on-premises Exchange. They do not describe Exchange Online.

Confirmed: the issue on on-premises Exchange after the October Windows Server updates, and a temporary workaround exists.
Likely: only servers that have installed the affected updates are at risk.
Unclear: the exact list of affected Exchange versions and build numbers. Check Microsoft's notice for the list. Do not rely on a summary for this.

Why this matters

- OWA sign-in failures and mail flow problems are user-visible and hit many people at once.
- A registry change applied to every server without a test can turn one problem into several.
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Exchange is often hybrid. Mail flow issues can affect Exchange Online users who route through on-premises servers.

What I would do

1. **Find the affected servers:** list Exchange servers and the installed Windows updates. Compare against Microsoft's notice.
2. **Pick one non-production or low-traffic server:** install the update there first if you have not yet, then test.
3. **Test the basics:** OWA sign-in with a test account, send and receive a message, check the message tracking log for delivery.
4. **Read the workaround completely:** check the exact key, the value, and whether a restart is needed. Do not copy a registry change from a forum post.
5. **Roll out in waves:** one server at a time, with a test after each step and a documented rollback.
6. **Monitor:** watch OWA and mail flow errors for a few days after each wave.

Risk and rollback

- **Risk of rolling out without a test:** High for affected servers.
- **Risk of waiting:** Depends on your patch policy and exposure. Discuss it with the security owner rather than deciding alone.
- **Rollback:** Microsoft's notice describes the workaround; reverse it only as the notice says. Keep the previous state documented before you change anything.

Verification

- Test account OWA sign-in works on the first server after the update.
- Test mail is sent and received, and the message tracking log shows delivery.
- Each wave has a recorded result before the next wave starts.

Source: BleepingComputer, 19 Oct 2026, as summarised in the weekly briefing on this site. Read Microsoft's notice before you change anything.